Christmas List 2025

Preferred Gift List for this Holiday Season

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Prologue

This list is meant to be a guide, not a set of expectations. Just because something appears here doesn't mean I'm asking for it or assuming I'll receive it, it's simply a way to share ideas and make things easier if you'd like some direction.

Handmade and personal gifts are always welcome and appreciated, no matter their "value" compared to anything on this list. You all know me well, and if something comes to mind that isn't written here but feels "very me," I would absolutely love that instead.

If you do decide to use this list, please coordinate with each other so things don't get duplicated. Most of all, I'm grateful for the thought behind any gift, and for you taking the time to even read this.

Gift Recommendations

Blender

Background

Over the past year I've started taking my health much more seriously, especially my diet. I now track my macro- and micronutrients closely and have noticed a few gaps, mainly potassium and additional protein. The most practical way for me to cover those is to add a daily smoothie that can catch whatever nutrients don't fit elsewhere in my meals. I've held off on buying a blender so far because counter space in my studio apartment is limited, and I want to invest in a high-quality blender that I'll use for a long time.

Recommendations

From my experience, Vitamix seems to make the most reliable, long-lasting blenders. They're admittedly a bit overpowered for everyday use, but that design margin appears to translate into motor longevity. My parents have a Vitamix 5200 that has handled a near-commercial workload for almost five years with no issues. I'd prefer a black model, but I'd completely understand choosing a different color if there's a significant discount.

Figure 1: Vitamix 5200 Blender

Links

[Vitamix Website]

[Vitamix Shop]

Vitamix Certified Reconditioned

Amazon Link

Other model on Amazon that is on sale often

Running Socks

Background

I got back into running in March of this year, and it has become a consistent part of my routine, culminating in running the Madison Half Marathon in October. As my mileage increased, I realized that my old, generic socks just weren't cutting it. On my parents' recommendation, I tried my first pair of high-quality running socks, and the difference was immediately noticeable in terms of comfort, support, and how my feet felt after longer runs. Now, by the time I'm halfway through the week and my Swiftwicks are in the laundry, it's genuinely hard to go back to my old pairs.

Recommendations

I've really liked the Swiftwick socks I've been using and would love to round out my rotation with about three more pairs. My preference is for white, no-show styles that work well with both running shoes and everyday wear, but I'm also open to other neutral colors but only if they are at a good discount.

Figure 2: Swiftwick Socks

Links

[Amazon Link]

Cycling

Background

This past year I have paired my running with cycling, oftentimes biking around the many paths in Minneapolis and the metro as well as the Paul Bunyan Trail in northern Minnesota with my dad. In the process I have slowly worked on optimizing my bike to fit my training needs. This has included moving the aerobars higher and mounting my phone on them, switching to a seat that better fits my pelvic bone, and installing a power meter to better understanding my training load.

While I am unable to ride in the winter, I would like to make some more involved improvements to the setup including switching to larger tires and rewrapping the grips. For that, the following would be needed:

Links

Bicycle Handlebar Wrap Tape

In combination with

Bike Handlebar Gel Pads

28mm Bike Tires

And accompanying tubes

Intangibles

Flight Training

Background

Flying has been a thread running through my life for more than a decade. For my 13th birthday in 2014, I was given a gift certificate to Stanton Airfield for my very first flight lesson. That experience completely hooked me on aviation.

In 2019, I finally had the time and resources to make real progress toward my Private Pilot's License (PPL), including solo flying and building the required hours. Unfortunately, COVID and then a college schedule forced me to put my training on hold before I could finish.

Figure 3: Myself at Stanton Airfield circa 2014

Now that I'm working full-time for an aerospace company, aviation has become not just a personal passion but also a professional one. This past September, my employer offered an instrument rating ground school, which would give me the endorsement needed to sit for the instrument written exam. To fully benefit from that, I first need to complete my PPL.

Starting in October, I've gotten back in the air and resumed structured training. My near-term goal is to complete the PPL and then move directly into instrument training so I can become a safer, more capable pilot.

Figure 4: Myself and N149AC

Private Pilot's License Flight Training

By 2019, I had already built a solid foundation toward the PPL requirements, including solo time and cross-country experience. Using my existing logbook totals, I've put together a conservative estimate of what remains to finish the license.

The lessons outlined in the table (review flights, solo cross-country, night requirements, and checkride preparation) are structured to get me back to proficiency, complete the remaining FAA requirements, and prepare thoroughly for the checkride. The total below assumes a "worst case" scenario, more realistically once I knock the rust off I expect to come in under these numbers.

Completing this phase will get me across the finish line on a lifelong goal in earning my Private Pilot's License and being able to act as pilot in command, carrying friends and family on personal trips.

Lesson Description	**Dual**	**Solo**	**TT**	**Cost**
Lesson 1: Return to Flight at OEO	1.5		32.5	$277.50
Lesson 2: Return to Flight at OEO	1.5		34.0	$277.50
Lesson 3: Return to Solo at OEO	0.7	1.2	35.9	$273.50

Lesson 4: Dual XC to Towered Solos OEO - STP - OEO	1.1	0.8	37.8	$299.50
Lesson 5: Night Dual Req's OEO - EAU - OEO	3.5		41.3	$647.50
Lesson 6: Three-Leg Solo XC OEO - RCX - EAU - OEO		2.9	44.2	$348.00
Lesson 7: Solo XC Top-Up		1.6	45.8	$192.00
Lesson 8: Checkride Prep #1	2.0		47.8	$370.00
Lesson 9: Checkride Prep #2	2.0		49.8	$370.00
PPL Checkride with DPE		2.5	52.3	$1,100.00
PPL Completion Totals			**52.3**	**$4,155.50**

Figure 5: PPL Completion Totals

Instrument Flight Training

Once the PPL is complete, the next major step is the Instrument Rating. This allows a pilot to fly in the clouds and in reduced visibility using instruments alone, which dramatically increases both safety and utility. It's also closely related to the kind of work I do in my day job in aerospace, so many of the concepts (navigation systems, procedures, and weather) already feel intuitive.

The instrument training plan below is again intentionally conservative. It includes foundational IFR lessons, simulated instrument cross-country flights, approaches of various types (precision and non-precision), abnormal procedures, and a long IFR cross-country, followed by focused checkride prep.

This rating is a significant milestone in that it turns flying from a good-weather recreational activity into a skillset that can be used more reliably and safely in real-world conditions. It also lays the groundwork for future commercial and multi-engine training.

Lesson Description	**Dual**	**Solo**	**TT**	**Cost**
IFR Foundations and Scan - Local	2.0		54.3	$567.00
Intercepts, Tracking and First Approaches - XC	2.0		56.3	$567.00
Simulated IFR XC #1	2.0		58.3	$567.00
Non-Precision Approaches - XC	2.2		60.5	$623.70
PIC XC #1 - with CFII	2.0		62.5	$567.00
Partial Panel & Unusual Attitudes - XC	2.0		64.5	$567.00

Simulated IFR XC #2	2.0		66.5	$567.00
Precision Approach Polishing - XC	2.5		69.0	$708.75
PIC XC #2		2.0	71.0	$352.00
Arcs and Course Reversal - XC	2.0		73.0	$567.00
Simulated IFR XC #3	2.0		75.0	$567.00
Non-Towered IFR Ops - XC	2.0		77.0	$567.00
PIC XC #3		2.0	79.0	$352.00
Abnormals and Lost Comms - XC	2.0		81.0	$567.00
Simulated IFR XC #4	2.0		83.0	$567.00
Long 250nm IFR XC	4.5		87.5	$1,275.75
PIC XC #4		2.0	89.5	$352.00
Circling, Missed Approaches, and Holds - XC	2.4		91.9	$680.40
Simulated IFR XC #5	2.0		93.9	$567.00
Checkride Prep #1	2.0		95.9	$567.00
Checkride Prep #2	2.2		98.1	$623.70
Instrument Checkride		2.5	100.6	$1,240.00
IR Completion Totals			**100.6**	**$12,339.30**

Future Training

After earning my instrument rating, the next goal is to work toward being paid for flying by obtaining commercial pilot privileges. To do that efficiently, the plan is to combine time-building with structured training and to “double dip” some of the multi-engine time so it counts both toward a Multi-Engine Rating and the commercial requirements in turn saving roughly $10,000.

Most of these hours can be flown as discretionary recreational trips: taking friends or family on flights (not for hire), exploring new airports, and using aviation to travel. That makes the required time both more affordable and more enjoyable to accumulate.

The multi-engine portion focuses on systems, flows, and normal procedures in a twin-engine aircraft, followed by intensive training on engine-out scenarios, single-engine approaches, abnormal procedures, and checkride preparation. This culminates in the Multi-Engine Rating, which is a key step for any advanced flying or future professional opportunities.

Lesson Description	Dual	Solo	TT	Cost
Systems, Flows and Normal Ops	2.0		102.6	$996.00
Engine-Out Basics at Altitude	2.0		104.6	$996.00
Vmc Demo and Drag Awareness	1.9		106.5	$946.20
EFATO and Accelerate-Stop/Go	2.0		108.5	$996.00
Single Engine Approaches	2.0		110.5	$996.00
Abnormals and SE/Missed Hold	2.0		112.5	$996.00
Short/Soft and Crosswinds	1.9		114.4	$946.20
Checkride Prep #1	2.0		116.4	$996.00
Checkride Prep #2	2.0		118.4	$996.00
Multi Checkride		2.5	120.9	$976.25
Multi Completion Totals			**120.9**	**$9,840.65**

Figure 6: Multi-Engine Rating

The final phase is completing the remaining Commercial ASEL (single-engine land) and AMEL (multi-engine land) requirements. This includes complex time (e.g., in a Bonanza), time in a Technically Advanced Aircraft, specific commercial maneuvers, long cross-country flights, and additional night and solo time. Together, these pieces satisfy the FAA commercial requirements and open the door to being compensated for certain types of flying.

Flight Hours Description	Dual	Solo	TT	Cost
Bonanza Complex Time incl 300nm Commercial XC	3		123.9	$1,327.50
C172 G1000 TAA Time	10		133.9	$3,225.00
Dual commercial ASEL Specific Lessons (incl Checkride Prep)	13		146.9	$3,347.50
300nm commercial XC		6	152.9	$900.00
Night PIC		5.5	158.4	$825.00
Time Building (cheap)		91.6	250.0	$12,366.00
Commercial ASEL Checkride		2.5	252.5	$1,212.50

Commercial ASEL Totals			**252.5**	**$23,203.50**

Figure 7: Commercial ASEL

Description	**Dual**	**Solo**	**TT**	**Cost**
Dual Multi Training	10		262.5	$4,980.00
Dual Checkride Prep	4		266.5	$1,992.00
Commercial AMEL Checkride		3	269.5	$2,171.50
Commercial AMEL Totals			**269.5**	**$9,143.50**

Figure 8: Commercial AMEL

Summary

Completing my flight training, my Private Pilot's License, earning an Instrument Rating, and ultimately obtaining my Commercial and Multi-Engine certifications, is a long-term goal I've been working toward since my very first lesson at Stanton Airfield in 2014. It's something I'm committed to achieving regardless of whether it's supported as a gift, and with or without help, I plan to continue funding this training over the next several years. That said, any contribution toward lessons, flight hours, or checkride fees would directly and tangibly move me closer to each milestone, turning what can feel like a very large total into manageable steps.

This is no longer just a hobby for me as it ties directly into my work in aerospace and the kind of career and life I'm building. Flying makes the world feel both larger and more connected, and as I progress, I'd love to "return the favor" by planning future cross-country flights to visit the people who helped make it possible. Above all, I'm genuinely grateful for any support, whether financial or simply encouragement, that helps me move closer to realizing this lifelong dream of becoming a fully qualified, instrument-rated commercial pilot.